

WAU-BUN

The Early Day in the Northwest

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Modernized Edition

PREFACE

Whenever a book takes the form of an autobiography, the public expects an apology to come with it. To refuse that tradition is basically to plead guilty to the charge so often aimed at Americans—that we are far too eager to force our private lives and domestic histories down our neighbors' throats.

It's to dodge this exact accusation that travelers usually offer some modest, built-in excuse to the reader: "These chapters were originally just private letters written to friends, never meant for the public eye, and they are only being published now because wiser judges convinced the author to do so."

I don't have that excuse. The record of these events—events in which I often played no part whatsoever—was kept simply because a revered older relative, whose name pops up often in these pages, told me to do it. "My child," she would say, "write these things down exactly as I tell them to you. Someday, our children, and even complete strangers, will want to hear the story of our early lives and all the suffering we endured." And my greatest regret is that I let so much of what she told me slip away unrecorded, lost to my own negligence and procrastination.

As for the glimpses of domestic life you'll find here—preserved in old journals, letters, and memories—I probably could have waited until I was dead to let them see the light of day. Honestly, I assumed that would be their fate. I figured they'd be dragged out of a dusty trunk years from now to show a future generation what "The Early Day" in our Western homes actually looked like. None of us realized that the relentless, hungry march of progress would pave over the traces of our beginnings so quickly. In less than twenty-five years, the landscape has changed so drastically that a massive, intelligent public is now begging for information about the early settlement of this region—information that very few of us are still around to provide.

Some folks have suggested that comparing today's world with the past might help our younger generation. Maybe it will help the kids emigrating from their luxurious homes on the East Coast to handle the minor hardships they face today with a little more patience and grace. If this book manages to accomplish that even once, I'll gladly take the hit for sounding a bit egotistical by sharing so much of my own history.

Some might argue that the personal details could have been written more modestly in the third person, or that I should have just described the events and scenery while keeping the actual people in the background. But if I did that, the story would lose its ring of truth and reality. It would be like building a beautiful theater set, turning on the lights, and then forgetting to invite the actors.

Some readers might think that living among the Native Americans and growing attached to them has clouded my judgment, making me exaggerate my sympathy for them and the wrongs they've suffered at the hands of white settlers. This isn't the place to debate that. There is a higher tribunal where every man will be judged for how he treated his fellow man.

I only hope our countrymen make sure their laws never make them ashamed to stand before that tribunal.

CHICAGO, July 1855.

CHAPTER I: Departure from Detroit

It was a dark, rain-swept evening in September of 1830 when we boarded the steamer Henry Clay, booking our passage for Green Bay. All our friends back in Detroit had been clapping us on the back, congratulating us on our incredible luck. We were being spared the nightmare of traveling on one of the tiny, precarious schooners that, back then, were the only way to reach the remote settlements scattered along Lakes Huron and Michigan.

Everyone had a horror story to share about those boats. They talked about agonizing, endless delays on the St. Clair flats, brutal headwinds howling off Thunder Bay, and the maddening, glass-flat calms that stranded ships at Mackinac or the Manitous. What made us feel especially lucky was a true story about one of our own relatives. He had left Detroit in June and didn't reach Chicago until September. He spent three miserable months making a trip that a decent sailboat can pull off in four days.

But honestly, the certainty of a bad trip wouldn't have stopped me. I was finally going to visit—and live in—the land that had captivated my imagination since I was a child. Back then, my greatest joy was reading letters from a beloved relative describing his wild life in the "Indian country," and later, his vivid stories of traveling with General Cass to the headwaters of the Mississippi in 1820. Even earlier than that, I remember standing at my teacher's knee, sounding out the massive, impossible word: Mich-i-li-mack-i-nac. That distant frontier, with its massive lakes, boundless prairies, and deep, ancient forests, had a grip on my mind. And now, I was going to see it. It was going to be my home.

Our ride to the docks set the tone for the adventure. We took a cart—the only vehicle that could navigate the dark, muddy, unpaved back alleys of Detroit—and laughed the whole way. Getting down to the Ladies' Cabin felt like descending a steep, perpendicular ladder in a mine shaft, but once we were there, it felt like the absolute

climax of luxury. My only company in the cabin was another woman and two little girls.

The first twenty-four hours were perfect. We had military officers onboard—old friends, as it turned out. We had plenty of books. The men read aloud, smoked cigars, played euchre, and stared out at the unbroken tree lines and the vast, empty water.

Then we hit Thunder Bay. True to its name, a storm rolled in, fast, vicious, and unrelenting. The boat pitched and rolled violently. We handled the closeness and the sea-sickness well enough—we knew it was coming and were prepared for it. But then a new nightmare started that nearly broke us.

Rain poured through every seam and pore in the deck above us. It ran down the stairs, soaking the carpet and then the bedding until we were literally driven out of the Ladies' Cabin by stress of weather. We fled to the Gentlemen's Cabin, and the men gallantly made room for us. We were just starting to congratulate ourselves on finding a dry haven when the seams above that cabin gave way, too. Water poured down on our heads in sheets. We popped open our umbrellas right there in the cabin, but it wasn't enough. The women and children retreated to the only dry berths left, and we stayed holed up there all day, eating dinner on our pillows. The men sat under their umbrellas in the dampest spots, telling amusing stories and jokes to keep our spirits up. Finally, at nine o'clock that night, the rain stopped, and we heard the glorious news: we had reached the pier at Mackinac.

Robert and Mrs. Stuart were waiting for us. You don't know true comfort until you've been tossed around and drenched on a freezing, leaking boat and then shoved into a warm house with a roaring fire and friends who genuinely care about you. It instantly chased away the fatigue and annoyance.

After a long, pleasant conversation, the servants gathered, a chapter from the Bible was read, a hymn was sung, and we finally went to bed.

I won't try to paint a full portrait of the noble friends I met that night. Someone with a better pen than mine should write the biography of Robert Stuart. Anyone who knew him—or better yet, stayed under his hospitable roof—will never forget his noble bearing, his warm humor, his relentless kindness, his uncompromising morals, and his pure philanthropy. Washington Irving in his *Astoria* and Franchère in his *Narrative* captured his wild, romantic early life, but they left out the best part: his later years as a true Christian gentleman.

As for his beloved wife, who is still alive and mourning her solitary path, I will just offer my love and prayers.

CHAPTER II: Michilimackinac

Mackinac! That absolute gem of the Lakes!

You can't imagine how vibrant and beautiful it looked as we stepped outside the following morning. The rain had passed, leaving everything glittering in the sunlight as it rose over the waters of Lake Huron, far to the east. Before us lay the bay, still churning slightly from the storm, but already dotted with canoes and fishermen casting their nets for trout and whitefish—the true treasures of the deep. Along the beach, the Ottawa Indians had set up their scattered wigwams to trade. As we approached, they came out to stare at us. A shout of welcome went up when they recognized Shaw-nee-aw-kee, who was well known to all of them after living there for seven years.

A solid handshake and an emphatic "Bon-jour—bon-jour!" was the standard greeting between the Native Americans and the white men.

"Do the Indians speak French?" I asked my husband.

"No," he said, "it's just a habit they picked up from the French traders over decades of interaction."

The Canadian boatmen were just as loud. They trotted up to pay their respects to "Monsieur John," rattling off a long string of congratulations in a thick, incomprehensible patois. I had to assume the best about the wishes they showered on "Madame John," since the only thing I could understand was their hope that I would be happy and contented in my "vie sauvage" (wild life).

The whole point of our early walk was to visit the Mission house and school, which the Presbyterian Board of Missions had established a few years earlier. It was a pet project of Mr. and Mrs. Stuart, and seeing it thriving gave them immense joy. They had lived on the island for years and watched it transform, through sheer Christian grit, from a wild, drunken outpost into a community where religion was treated like serious business. The school was the beating heart of the few Protestant families living there. Thanks to the relentless work of Mr. and Mrs. Ferry, the school was famous. It was fascinating to see the effect of education on these kids—calming the wild, tricky nature of the half-breeds and waking up the stoic apathy of the Native children.

These were the glory days of Mackinac. It was the headquarters of the American Fur Company and the central hub of the entire Northwest. Every single trade—supplies going out, furs coming in—flowed through this parent establishment and its scattered outposts along Lake Superior, Lake Michigan, and the Mississippi River.

Most people know that after the French lost their territories to the British, the Native tribes (except the Miamis and Wyandots) stayed fiercely loyal to the Crown. The American Revolution didn't change that, and the U.S. Government never managed to buy their friendship. Great Britain played a long, smart game. Every year, the leaders of the Chippewa, Ottawa, Potawatomi, Menomonee, Winnebago, Sac, and Fox tribes traveled thousands of miles to Fort Malden in Canada just to collect their annual presents from their "Great Father" across the ocean. It was a masterstroke of policy, keeping the tribes on the payroll so they could unleash them as devastating allies during the last war.

The British didn't skimp, either. They handed out blankets, broadcloth, calico, guns, kettles, traps, mirrors, combs, and silver jewelry—arm-bands, bracelets, brooches, and earrings.

The Fur Company storehouses at Mackinac were where these tribes came to sell their goods and buy whatever the British hadn't given them—which mostly meant ammunition and liquor.

They brought in massive hauls of fur: beaver, otter, marten, mink, silver-gray fox, red fox, wolf, bear, wild-cat, musk-rat, and smoked deer-skins. They also brought tons of maple sugar, Indian corn, beans, and wild rice. The women traded beautiful moccasins, hunting pouches, woven mats, toy snowshoes, and "mococks"—little birch-bark boxes heavily embroidered with porcupine quills and packed with maple sugar.

It was entirely normal to see a fleet of a hundred Indian canoes hitting the island at once, loaded down with goods. When you added the massive Mackinac boats arriving from the remote posts packed with buffalo robes and pelts, you started to grasp the sheer scale of the American Fur Company and the thousands of human lives tied to it.

Looking at these uncultivated people, it was easy for a philanthropic mind to dream of a future where white men sacrificed their own fortunes to lift their red brethren up the ladder of civilization—a future where education and Christianity walked hand-in-hand to make the wilderness bloom.

None of the noble souls celebrating the success of the Mackinac mission realized that in less than twenty-five years, these massive tribes would be reduced to a few scattered, starving bands. Their lands would be stolen or swindled away, their ancestral graves plowed over, and the people themselves chased further and further west until they were begrudged even a patch of dirt to die on.

Our visit to the Mission school was cut short because the Henry Clay was scheduled to leave at two o'clock. We spent our last hour walking the white, gravelly roads, taking in the old houses. My husband pointed out the home of Madame Laframboise, a

formidable Ottawa woman whose husband had taught her to read and write. When her husband was murdered at a trading post by a Winnebago named White Ox, she took over the business. She personally visited the remote posts, managed the clerks and boatmen, and ran the entire operation with an iron fist. She also brought students into her home every day, teaching them to read and schooling them in the Catholic faith.

The Agency house, with its luxurious porches and gardens, sat at the bottom of the steep hill crowned by the fort. The rickety, primitive wooden buildings used by the Fur Company didn't reflect well on my husband's architectural skills—though he defended himself by pointing out he was barely more than a boy when he oversaw their construction.

By the time we got to Mr. Mitchell's house for dinner, my head was throbbing violently from the previous day's motion sickness. I tried not to complain, but a woman visiting the Mission insisted I lie down on the sofa. She sat beside me, soothing my head and asking questions about my future in the wild.

"Aren't you worried about losing all your religious privileges out there?" she asked.

"It will be hard," I admitted, "but not entirely lost. I have my Prayer-Book. Even without a church, we won't be without a way to worship."

How many times in the lonely years that followed did I think back to that conversation, thanking God for the comfort of that book in the middle of the wilderness.

Before we even finished dinner, the steamer's bell rang, summoning us aboard. We said rushed goodbyes to our friends and hurried to the docks.

Mackinac from the water is a breathtaking sight. As we steamed away, the whole picture opened up—the sloping beaches dotted with wigwams, the quirky, irregular houses, the gleaming white walls of the fort, and the towering remains of old Fort Holmes looking down over it all.

Then there was the water itself. It was so pure and clear you could watch fish darting through the depths. You could see objects fifty or sixty feet down; a silver dollar resting on the green bottom looked no bigger than a dime.

As we cleared the western edge of the island, my husband pointed far away to the northwest to Point St. Ignace. It is one of the oldest white settlements on the continent. Jesuit missionaries built a church and a school there in 1607—the exact same year St. Augustine was settled in Florida, and a year before Jamestown, Virginia. All that

remains of those devoted men is the memory of their work, preserved only in the names of the places they visited.

We passed "Old Mackinac" on the mainland, a place soaked in blood. Every history buff knows the story of Pontiac's Rebellion. The Indians played a "friendly" game of lacrosse outside the fort's walls to draw out the British officers and soldiers. When the ball was conveniently tossed over the wall, the warriors rushed the gates, pulled their hidden weapons, and massacred the entire garrison.

As the sun began to set, the tiny Indian village of L'Arbre Croche gleamed in the distance. Other than that, there wasn't a single sign of human life on that massive, wooded shoreline. The giant trees and little prairie glades looked like an agricultural paradise waiting to happen, but it was completely untrodden. We left it to its solitude and pushed west across the open water.

The violent, gusty rainstorms caught up with us again before we reached the mouth of Green Bay, sticking with us until we hit the mud flats three miles below the settlement. The steamer ran aground, stuck fast and hard. Since no one wanted to stay cooped up in the cabin for another night, we braved the wind, rain, and pitch-black darkness in a tiny rowboat, finally pulling ourselves onto the shore.

CHAPTER III: Green Bay

Our timing in arriving at Green Bay was absolutely terrible. It happened to be the exact time the United States Government was negotiating a massive treaty with the Menomonee and Waubesa tribes. As a result, not only were the treaty commissioners and their endless parade of clerks and officials there, but the town was completely overrun with traders, land claimants, travelers, and drifters.

Almost all of these people were crammed into the only hotel the town had to offer. It was a decent-sized place down near the river, but when we walked into the long dining room—freezing cold and dripping wet from the open boat—we were blown away by the chaotic mob inside. People were clustered in groups, arguing and talking over each other. New arrivals like us just stood around aimlessly because there weren't nearly enough chairs for everyone.

The landlord sat there in the middle of the madness, completely indifferent, his hands shoved deep into his pockets. He had all the unbothered calm of a Pennsylvania Dutchman. His wife, on the other hand, was a force of nature. She was bustling around the room, pausing to scream at some employee who had messed up a chore, and then spinning around to laugh until her sides shook at a joke someone had made.

She welcomed us warmly, but when we asked if she had a room, she shot us down instantly. "Not a chance. I've got twice as many people in this house right now as I know what to do with. I even had to kick my own family out of their beds just to cram in all these treaty commissioners and the mob that followed them."

"What are we supposed to do?" we asked. "It is way too late and stormy to try and hike up to Shanty-town to find a place."

"Well, just sit down and eat some supper," she said, "and we'll see what we can figure out."

True to her word, she actually managed to clear out a tiny closet of a room where we could hide from the madness. Unfortunately, our "asylum" was separated by nothing more than a thin wooden partition from the room occupied by General Root of New York, one of the lead treaty commissioners.

The steamer that brought us had also brought the mail, which was a massive deal in these isolated settlements. For General Root, this meant every single dispatch and letter had to be opened and read aloud before he went to sleep. Because his eyesight was failing, his secretaries had to read the documents to him. And because he was going deaf, they had to shout them.

Through the paper-thin wall, every single word of the political dispatches—and the General's loud, unfiltered commentary on them—was painfully clear.

"What is that, Walter? Read that over again!" he kept shouting.

We tried everything. We coughed loudly. We cleared our throats. We banged the furniture around. It was entirely useless. They were so deeply engrossed in their work that they didn't hear a thing. If we had been rival politicians, we could have taken notes and made a fortune off the secrets we overheard that night.

The next morning, it was still pouring. Rain, rain, and more rain. Despite the weather, the men had to take a small boat back out to the stranded steamer to retrieve the luggage. The most critical part of that cargo was several heavy boxes of silver that my husband needed to pay the annual treaty annuities to the Winnebagoes at the Portage.

I walked out onto the covered porch with some of the other guests to watch them leave. Someone pointed out Fort Howard to me, sitting on a jagged point on the opposite shore about three-quarters of a mile away. The old barracks, the wooden pickets, and the walls looked strangely ancient, considering how recently they had been built.

We quickly turned our attention back to the small boat, which was now in the middle of the river. One of the men was standing up in the back, trying to shout directions to the rowers.

"That guy is taking a serious risk," one of the men on the porch said. "If he isn't careful, he's going to lose his balance."

At that exact second, we watched the man do a perfect, uncontrolled backflip and disappear into the freezing water.

"Oh my God, he's going to drown!" I screamed.

The men around me just laughed. "No, there he is. They're pulling him back in."

The boat immediately turned around and rowed back to shore. It wasn't until the man climbed out, dripping wet and laughing, that I realized it was my husband. He thought the whole thing was hilarious, but to me, it felt like a very dark omen for my new life in the West.

He finally let his friends convince him to leave the luggage to them. He changed his clothes and agreed to stay quietly at the hotel with me. Just as things calmed down, a carriage pulled up to the door, and we saw the friendly face of Judge Doty.

He had heard about our arrival and came straight over to rescue us from the hotel and take us to his house. We didn't hesitate. We grabbed our bags and baskets and practically ran to his carriage.

The drive took us past Navarino, then dragged us through Shanty-town—which was a painfully accurate name—plowing through deep mud, over terrible, rutted roads, and up and down hills that felt like they were going to break our necks. We finally reached the Dotys' beautiful little brick home. Mrs. Doty welcomed us with such genuine, sisterly kindness that we instantly felt like we were home.

Because they had been expecting us, they had already sent out invitations to the entire social circle of Green Bay for an evening party. In a new, isolated town, throwing a massive party was the standard way of honoring new arrivals.

We also learned that Captain Harney, who had offered to come down from Fort Winnebago with a boat and a crew of soldiers to take us home, hadn't arrived yet. This meant we had a few free days to relax and actually enjoy the society at "the Bay."

For people living completely cut off from the rest of the world, we were a goldmine. We spent the day answering a never-ending stream of questions. They

wanted to know everything we had brought from the East—politics, society gossip, fashion trends, and all the little details the newspapers never bothered to print.

Everyone at the party, except for me, had already made the brutal trip up the Fox River and down the Wisconsin River to the Mississippi, so they traded war stories.

There was a hilarious story about a recent trip taken by three men, accompanied by a French trader and his two sisters, who were experiencing frontier travel for the first time. The men laughed about how Mademoiselle Julie would sneak into their bags and steal their expensive damask napkins just to wipe out the raw ducks before cooking them. They talked about the absolute impossibility of convincing the sisters that they needed to wash the dishes **before** packing them away in the mess-basket. As a result, the men constantly had to steal the napkins back just to wipe the grease off their plates before every meal. One young man even spent hours hunting down his stolen clothes, tying them to a rope, and dragging them behind the boat down the Wisconsin River just to get them clean.

Then there was a classic story about M. Rolette. Somewhere on a previous trip—probably crossing Winnebago Lake—the travelers ran into a Fur Company supply boat heading to Green Bay. Rolette was a high-ranking agent for the company, and the men in the boat worked for him. Since Rolette had been away from home for weeks, running into his own men on the lonely water was a huge deal.

The boats pulled up alongside each other, and Rolette immediately started firing off questions.

"Have they finished the new house?" "Yes, sir." "Does the chimney smoke?" "No, sir." "How is the harvest?" "Very fine." "Is the mill working?" "Yes, plenty of water." "How is Whip?" (His favorite horse.) "Whip is doing great."

Once he was satisfied that his store, his farm, and his business were all running perfectly, Rolette was ready to leave.

"Alright then—goodbye! Safe travels!" He yelled to his rowers, "Go ahead, men!" But a second later, he panicked and yelled, "Stop! Stop!" He leaned over the boat and asked, "How are Mrs. Rolette and the children?"

We finally went to bed that night, thrilled that we didn't have to sleep next to General Root and his screaming political secretaries.

My sleep, however, wasn't exactly peaceful. Right before dawn, I was jolted awake by a sound coming from the kitchen directly below our room. It was a slow, mournful

chant that rose and fell in a strange, haunting rhythm. To me, it sounded unearthly—wild, strange, and terrifying. I shook my husband awake in a panic.

He just smiled and told me it was the morning salutation of the Indians.

A group of Menomonees had been allowed to sleep in the kitchen to escape the storm, and they were simply following their absolute tradition of singing a hymn to greet the sunrise. Once they finished, they went right back to sleep.

I couldn't go back to sleep. I lay there, completely struck by the beauty of these untaught men of the forest singing their morning praise. It felt like a sharp lesson to the civilized, Christian world, where so many people go to bed and wake up without ever thanking God for keeping them alive. That simple, pure act of worship stuck with me forever.

Later that day, Mr. and Miss Cadle came to visit. They were in the middle of launching an ambitious project to build a school for Native and half-breed children. They hadn't built the schoolhouse or the chapel yet, but we visited the site and listened to their massive plans to tame the wilderness and bring Christianity to the tribes. History has shown exactly how hard it is for a few zealous people to fight against the overwhelming greed of the masses, but their hope was inspiring.

The evening party was exactly what you'd expect, but the most interesting part for me was talking to the local Green Bay girls. Many of them were daughters of French settlers and Menomonee women. One group, the Grignon sisters, traced their French lineage all the way back to the family of Madame de Sévigné. They were incredibly elegant, dignified, and spoke with soft, musical voices.

But their unfiltered innocence genuinely terrified me. When I mentioned how excited I was to finally see Fort Winnebago, they looked at me like I was crazy.

"You aren't afraid of the snakes?" one asked.

"Snakes? Are there snakes at the fort?"

"At the Portage? Oh, God, yes! You can't even walk outside. Rattlesnakes, copperheads, all of them!"

I am not a naturally fearful person, but the idea of living in a place completely overrun with rattlesnakes wasn't exactly comforting.

One of the young women at the party was stunningly beautiful, tall and graceful, and it was a genuine tragedy to everyone when she later abandoned society to join a convent.

Captain Harney finally arrived with his boat, and Mrs. Doty immediately took charge of packing for our journey. She loaded a massive mess-basket with ham, tongue, biscuits, and plum-cake, alongside hardtack and boiled pork—though she joked that a proper lady was supposed to be too fastidious to touch salt pork, even if she was starving in the woods.

We hired three Canadian voyageurs to handle the heavy lifting. Their job was to chop firewood, cook our meals, and do the manual labor. We also sent a messenger ahead to the Kakalin rapids, twenty-one miles upriver, to hire Wish-tay-yun, the most legendary guide on the river, to navigate us through the dangerous passes.

Before we left, the town threw one last massive party—a real "Western hop" at Mrs. Baird's house. Everyone in the region showed up. The young military officers came up from Fort Howard looking sharp in their uniforms, and the locals dragged out finery they hadn't worn in years. To make room for the dancing, Mr. Baird's office was completely cleared of desks, and even the kitchen was opened up for the older men who just wanted to sit quietly and smoke cigars.

The party was loud, chaotic, and incredibly fun. In a new settlement, parties are judged by how many people show up, not by how exclusive they are, so the crowd was a wild mix of everyone.

I realized this pretty quickly when a short, clumsy man with a bright red face waddled across the room and sat down next to me.

"Miss K—," he said loudly, "nobody bothered to introduce us, but I've seen you around, and I know your husband, so I figured I'd just come talk to you. I'm A—."

"Nice to meet you, Mr. A—," I said politely. "Are you having a good time? How is your sister?"

"Oh, she's terrible. Her cold got right into her eye, and it's completely swollen shut."

Before I could respond, he spun around and stared at a stunning young woman sitting nearby. She was radiant, hilarious, and clearly the center of attention.

"Wow, Mrs. Beall!" he yelled. "You have a beautiful gown, and you look incredibly handsome! I swear you're the prettiest woman in the room, and you dance better than anyone here!"

She suppressed a laugh and looked at him demurely. "I'm afraid you're flattering me, Mr. A—."

"No I'm not!" he insisted. "I'm dead serious. I came over here to ask you to dance."

Such is the penalty for being too charming on the frontier.

CHAPTER IV: Voyage Up Fox River

It had been arranged that Judge Doty would travel with us in our boat as far as the Butte des Morts, where his attendant would be waiting with horses to take him overland to Mineral Point to hold court.

It was a brilliant, beautiful morning when we left his house to start our push up the Fox River. Captain Harney had planned to stay in Green Bay for a few more days, but he walked us down to the riverbank to make sure we were settled into the boat.

As he helped me navigate the plowed fields and mud down to the water, he told me how desperately Mrs. Twiggs—the wife of the commanding officer at Fort Winnebago—was waiting for me. She had been the only white woman at the fort since the spring. We had briefly met in New York shortly after her wedding, so we weren't complete strangers. I was confident that once I arrived—once my piano was safely unpacked, the library we bought was set up, and we had another woman to talk to—we would have a perfect little social circle, even out in the middle of the wilderness. I was incredibly optimistic.

Our transport was a thirty-foot Mackinac boat, rowed by a crew of soldiers and our three hired voyageurs. In the center of the boat, they had built a wooden frame covered in a canvas roof, with side curtains that could be rolled down like a stagecoach if it rained.

Right in the middle of this makeshift cabin sat the massive crate holding my piano. We threw a mattress over it, which gave us a couch during the day and a bed at night if the weather was too miserable to camp. Next to the piano were the heavy boxes of silver my husband needed to pay the Native annuities. Our mess-basket was close by, along with two large, square woven baskets we bought from the New York Indians to hold our clothes and bedding.

As a true New Englander, I had obviously packed my knitting and embroidery, along with plenty of books and pencils. Most of our actual furniture and household goods were following behind us in a separate boat. Navigating the rapids with heavy cargo took three weeks of brutal labor, and you were lucky if your furniture arrived broken and wet rather than lost entirely. Because of that, we crammed our most valuable possessions into our own boat, even if it meant we barely had room to move.

Before this trip, I had never seen a gentleman wearing a colored shirt. Where I was from, a crisp white collar was the absolute minimum standard for a man. But Mrs. Cass had warned me that out here, calico shirts and patch-work pillowcases were

essential survival gear. Thanks to a local Frenchwoman, our couch pillows were covered in bright, mismatched fabric.

My husband and the Judge fully embraced the frontier look, wearing bright blue and pink shirts. They both bought bright red stocking caps—*tuques*—which they put on whenever they needed a nap after a heavy meal.

The Judge was a fantastic traveling companion. He had lived out here for years, traveled with General Cass to the headwaters of the Mississippi, and had an endless supply of hilarious stories about the early days of the frontier.

He told us about an old French justice of the peace at Green Bay named Réaume. He was incredibly ignorant and greedy, though generally good-natured. Once, two men brought a dispute to him. Réaume listened to both sides, stood up, and delivered his verdict:

"You are both wrong. You, the plaintiff, will bring me one load of hay. And you, the defendant, will bring me one load of wood. The matter is settled." Nobody dared to appeal the decision.

That reminded the Judge of another story about a French justice in Prairie du Chien, known to everyone as "Old Boilvin." His office was just outside the fort, and the officers used to hang out there in the mornings just to watch him work and drink brandy-and-water with him, which he called "taking a little *quelque-chose*."

A soldier named Fry was accused of stealing and killing a calf belonging to the powerful trader M. Rolette. The constable dragged Fry into Boilvin's office while the officers were sitting there.

"Here is Fry, sir," the constable said.

Old Boilvin stood up and shook his fist. "Fry, you rascal! Why did you kill M. Rolette's calf?"

"I didn't kill his calf," Fry said.

"You're a liar!" Boilvin screamed. "Constable, take him to jail! Come, gentlemen, let us take a little *quelque-chose*."

The Canadian boatmen sang constantly while they rowed or paddled. The songs kept their rhythm, and they loved it when the *bourgeois* (the boss—in this case, my husband) led the singing. If the passengers joined in the chorus, they rowed even harder.

Their songs were fast and funny, usually built around a joke or a punchline that required everyone to scream the chorus. My husband would sing a verse about a rooster crowing, or listing off apples, pears, and radishes, and the men would roar the words back at him.

Another song gave endless advice on who not to marry: *Don't marry a brunette, they drink too much.* *Don't marry a redhead, they're too jealous.*

Once they exhausted every possible type of woman, my husband would shout, "Whoop la! à terre, pour la pipe!"

It was an iron-clad rule that the voyageurs stopped every five or six miles to rest and smoke their pipes. Distances out here weren't measured in miles; they were measured in "pipes."

The French-Canadian melodies were beautiful, and gliding across the wild, empty water to the rhythm of the oars and the singing was exhilarating. Their favorite song was a comedy routine about a man named Michaud who climbed a plum tree. The branch breaks, and the chorus screams, "Michaud fell down!" The boss asks, "Where is he?" and the crew yells, "He's on the ground!" Then everyone shouts for Michaud to wake up. They repeated the joke for every fruit tree in existence.

By the end of our first day, we reached the Kakalin rapids, where another branch of the Grignon family lived. They took us in and fed us venison steaks, fresh crêpes, and incredible coffee.

The Kakalin was a serious set of rapids. The boat had to be emptied and dragged up through the rocks with ropes. The next morning, my husband took charge of the men while I was thrown into a wooden ox-cart to bypass the muddy trails. Our driver navigated the cart by intentionally crashing his oxen into trees and stumps, nearly destroying my hat and bruising me entirely.

When I finally reached the top of the rapids, the boat was waiting. Our guide, Wish-tay-yun, walked up to me. He was a massive, good-humored Menomonee Indian.

"Bon-jour, maman!" he laughed.

I was shocked by the title. "Yes," my husband said, smiling. "You have a very large family now. All the Winnebagoes, Potawatomis, Chippewas, and Ottawas call me 'father,' so by default, you are their 'mother'."

We pushed off the bank. Before we got far, another boat rowed out to intercept us. It was Mr. Marsh, a missionary, and the Reverend Eleazar Williams, who lived among

the natives. Anyone arriving from the East was treated like a walking newspaper, so we had to stop and give them all the political and social updates we possessed.

When they asked me about my plans for the Native children at the fort, I had to admit I didn't have any. I didn't know anything about their culture yet; my only plan was to be their friend and figure out the rest later. Mr. Williams was incredibly quiet during the conversation. He had a dark, olive complexion, and if I hadn't known he was part Native, I would have assumed he was Spanish.

The next stretch of the river was brutal. Wish-tay-yun shouted directions, but the current was too strong. The boat wedged between two massive rocks.

"She won't budge!"

"Men overboard!" my husband yelled.

Every single man jumped over the side into the freezing, waist-deep water to drag the boat free. There were no songs that afternoon.

I had never seen men do such backbreaking physical labor before, and I felt terrible watching them suffer in the freezing water. What shocked me even more was when my husband—after eating lunch—stripped down to duck trousers and a light jacket, jumped into the freezing river, and grabbed an oar to give a frail, sick soldier a break. The kid was clearly a recruit who had no idea what he was signing up for. He eventually deserted the fort, and his body was found the next spring—he had either frozen or starved to death in the woods.

By the time we hit the "Grande Chûte," we had only made thirteen miles. We camped on a flat strip of land near the waterfall. It was my first time camping, and I was completely enchanted by it.

The men chopped down saplings, built massive fires, and set up our tents. I wandered over to the soldiers' fire and found a tall, awkward recruit stirring a pot of soup.

"They left me here to cook," he said. "I'm from the German Flats, and we love soup down there. My name is Krissman."

He told me he had joined the army because he knew how to blow a horn and figured if he became the bugler, he'd get extra pay.

The next morning, we were woken up at dawn by my husband shouting, "How! how! how!"

The men sprang out of their tents, rebuilt the fires, and had coffee, toast, and broiled ham ready in minutes. A French camp cook is an absolute miracle worker.

The men spent the entire morning dragging the heavy boat up the steep banks to bypass the waterfall. We walked through the woods, picking wildflowers and trying to stay out of the way. By the time we got back on the water, the river was calm again.

CHAPTER V: Winnebago Lake

We camped that night in a beautiful clearing near the "little Butte." The men chopped down a massive tree and built a roaring fire. Because the grass was so dry, the fire immediately spread, but the wind blew it away from the tents. We stood on logs and watched our "prairie fire" burn itself out.

The only downside was that it burned up all the dry grass I had planned to use as a mattress. We ate supper under the tall trees while the river murmured past us, and when the moon came up, the absolute isolation of the wilderness felt magical.

That peace was broken late at night by heavy footsteps outside the tent.

"Mr. Kinzie! Mr. Kinzie!" a voice boomed.

"Who is it?" my husband asked.

"It's Krissman! Did you mean for us to not get any liquor tonight? The corporal said you didn't specifically order it, but I figured I shouldn't be bashful and just come ask."

My husband laughed and ordered the rations handed out. Krissman was quickly becoming a legend.

The next morning, we rowed a few miles up to the entrance of Winnebago Lake and stopped at Four-Legs' village. It was a beautiful cluster of Indian huts shaded by massive trees, but the entire tribe was gone for the winter. We dropped off our guide, Wish-tay-yun, who shook my hand, called me "maman," and jogged off into the woods toward his home.

With him gone, our luck with the weather vanished. The sky turned black, and a freezing rain poured down on us. We spent the crossing huddled under the canvas roof of the boat. To pass the time, my husband told me a story about the chief, Four-Legs.

Years ago, my husband was living at Prairie du Chien, working for the Fur Company. He was suffering from a brutal case of malaria. One day, while he was shaking with fever, Chief Four-Legs walked into the warehouse to trade.

Native Americans don't stand on ceremony, so Four-Legs walked right up to my sick husband and started talking. And he wouldn't stop. He talked until my husband's head was pounding. Four-Legs insisted that a young man shouldn't be living alone, and that his daughter was a fantastic beaver trapper and would make a great wife.

Desperate for quiet, my husband deliriously agreed to marry her just to get the man to leave.

He completely forgot about the conversation until months later, when Four-Legs marched into the trading post with an incredibly ugly, middle-aged woman. She dropped a massive pack of furs at my husband's feet—the traditional Native way of sealing a marriage.

My husband panicked. He told the clerks to put the furs in the back, then turned to the chief and lied through his teeth.

"She is a wonderful woman," he told Four-Legs, "but Governor Cass just ordered me to Detroit. I'm going to be gone for years. If I marry her and leave, everyone will laugh at her. It's better if I just give you a massive pile of expensive blankets and guns, and you marry her to someone else."

Four-Legs was smart enough to take the payout. It cost my husband a fortune to buy his way out of the marriage, but he learned never to make deals while suffering from a fever. The Native Americans up north still jokingly call that woman by my husband's name.

We rowed past Garlic Island—a gorgeous spot ruined by its name—and pushed into the Fox River. The river was choked with miles of wild rice. The Native women harvest it by pulling their canoes through the stalks, beating the rice into the boats with their paddles, and fanning away the husks. It's not incredibly nutritious, but they use it to thicken venison soup.

CHAPTER VI: Breakfast at Betty More's

The ground was entirely flooded from the heavy rains, making it impossible to set up camp. We had to convert the center of the boat into a makeshift bedroom. Building a fire was a miserable task, but the men managed to dig out some dry grass and branches from deep inside the underbrush, and soon we had a fire blazing on the bank.

After sitting in the freezing rain all day, huddling around that fire felt incredible. We watched the Frenchmen work their magic—nestling a kettle into the hot coals, roasting thick slices of ham on sharpened sticks, and frying up a hissing pan of pork

and onions. You have to spend a freezing, starving day on the river to truly appreciate a hot meal like that.

The sun set in a brilliant explosion of color, promising better weather for the next day, and we happily went to sleep.

The next morning, we were woken up by the shout of our bourgeois. When I looked out of the boat, I saw a tall, incredibly athletic "mitiff" (half-breed) standing on the bank with a few Native men. They enthusiastically greeted my husband as "father" and me as their new "mother." These were the first Winnebagoes I had seen, and frankly, they were a rough-looking group.

The mitiff was a messenger from the Grignon family. He brought an invitation from Judge Law, who was camped a few miles upriver with some friends from Green Bay, asking us to join them for breakfast in his tent. We hadn't expected to see any white people out here, but in the wilderness, your presence is never a secret if there is a Native American within ten miles.

We immediately pushed off for the "Butte des Morts," or as our friend Mrs. A—famously insisted on calling it, "Betty More's."

We saw the Judge's white tent gleaming on a small hill long before we arrived. The river was absolutely jammed with canoes, mostly paddled by Native women. The banks were crowded with men carrying guns, because the air was thick with massive flocks of teal ducks. The wild rice fields around the lake made this area a paradise for the birds in the autumn. The rice makes the ducks incredibly fat and tender, but the locals warned us to only shoot the birds when they flew low—if you shot one high in the air, it would hit the ground so hard it would shatter and become inedible.

Our boat was quickly surrounded by a fleet of canoes. The Native women were laughing and chattering, holding out wooden bowls full of fresh cranberries as a welcoming gift for me. I threw hardtack crackers back to them. When the crackers hit the water, total chaos broke out. They dropped their paddles and scrambled over each other, screaming in triumph when they managed to grab a floating cracker.

My husband was on the bank, shaking hands with the chiefs. They were tall, powerfully built men who looked like they could survive anything the wilderness threw at them. One of them was bragging wildly about how much game was in the area. My husband handed him a pouch of ammunition, and the man immediately sprinted off to prove his claims.

We walked up to the Judge's tent and met him and a quiet French gentleman named Porlier. The camp was a study in contrasts: the French voyageurs were running

around working furiously, while the half-breeds just lounged around with complete apathy.

Breakfast was served on a woven Indian mat inside the tent. I was given the seat of honor at the head of the "table," looking out the open flap at the river. The tall half-breed messenger who had invited us was acting as our waiter. He was still wearing a calico shirt, a bright waist sash, and a straw hat covered in black ostrich feathers.

He handed out tin cups for coffee and tin plates for the food. The centerpiece of the meal was a massive pan of boiled ducks.

Judge Law was a man who liked things done perfectly, even in the middle of nowhere. He picked up his tin plate, noticed some dirt on it, and handed it over his shoulder to the servant. "Wipe this carefully," he ordered.

The servant didn't blink. He reached into his shirt, pulled out a filthy black silk handkerchief that he used for everything, furiously polished the tin plate with it, and handed it back. The Judge gave the plate a look of total approval, shot a glance around the table as if to say, *See how I maintain standards?*, and dug into his breakfast.

It was a good thing the Judge's horses were waiting to take him to Mineral Point immediately after breakfast, because if I had told him what I just saw, his ride would have been ruined.

Just as we finished eating, the Native hunter who had taken my husband's ammunition returned. He had shot fifty ducks in just over an hour. From that point on, we had fresh duck for every meal.

CHAPTER VII: Butte des Morts – Lake Puckaway

The Butte des Morts, or "Hillock of the Dead," earned its gloomy name from a massive, bloody battle between the French and the Fox Indians (the Mis-qua-kees). The slaughter was so horrific that the French buried the dead in a massive mound. The Fox tribe was completely crushed. They abandoned the river that bore their name, retreated to the Mississippi, and allied with the Sauks, which is why they are known today as the "Sauk and Foxes."

The French and half-breed settlers out here have nicknames for every single tribe, based on a specific trait or habit. The Chippewas are the "Jumpers" (Sauteurs) because they are so agile. The Ottawas are the "Short-ears" (Courtes-oreilles). The Menomonees are named after the wild rice in their territory (Folles Avoines). The Potawatomis are called "The Lice" (les Poux) because of their living conditions. The Foxes are "The

Foxes" (les Renards). The Winnebagoes are called "The Stinkers" (les Puans) because their warriors wear the fur of a polecat on their legs during battle.

No French trader will ever use a tribe's actual name. They will just ask, "Is she a Jumper?" or "Is he a Stinker?" It takes a while for a newcomer to figure out who is who. The Native friends surrounding us at the fort were all "Stinkers," though they preferred their actual name: the Ho-tshung-rahhs.

We said goodbye to Judge Doty and pushed on. The overland distance from the Butte des Morts to the Portage is about seventy miles. By water, it is over a hundred and thirty miles because the Fox River twists and turns like a snake through the swampy prairies.

The river's path is maddening. I was always looking for beautiful things to sketch, and at one point, I found a gorgeous cluster of trees sheltering a few wigwams on the riverbank. Naked children were running around, and two women were weaving mats on the ground. I grabbed my pencil and started drawing. The natives recognized my husband and started screaming his name and waving at us.

We kept rowing, and I kept sketching. Eventually, I noticed the sun was in the wrong place. When I started drawing, the sun was behind me. Then it was on my left. Now it was directly in front of me. I looked up to find a new scene to draw.

"Oh, look at that!" I said. "That is beautiful too. But it looks exactly like the place I just drew."

The people on the bank started screaming and laughing at us again. We had rowed for nearly four miles, only to navigate a massive hairpin turn that dropped us exactly where we had been an hour ago, just on the other side of the same bank. It destroys your soul as a traveler.

Late on the second day, we reached Lake Puckaway. A white man named Gleason lived there, a guy famous for wildly exaggerating everything. We didn't stay at his house because the mosquitoes were swarming in clouds. We dropped anchor as far from the shore as possible and slept in the boat.

The lake gets its name from the tall reeds that the Native women use to weave the mats that cover their wigwams. They lay the reeds out on the ground and use a flat bone needle threaded with tree-bark twine to stitch them tightly together. It's hard work, and the tribe leaves it to the older women. When a woman is too broken down from a life of hard labor to chop trees or carry heavy packs, she is relegated to weaving mats, watching the kids, and beating the dogs that infest every camp.

We crossed Buffalo Lake (Lac de Boeuf), a stunning sheet of water surrounded by thick forests where deer darted through the trees. The wild rice was thick, and flocks of cranes and teal ducks exploded out of the water as we passed.

But once we left the lake, the river became a nightmare again. For seventy miles, the scenery was dead and monotonous. We knew that if we had horses, we could have crossed the prairie from Gleason's to the fort in three hours. Instead, we were stuck on a narrow, twisting river. The Frenchmen couldn't even sing because the river was so narrow their oars kept hitting the banks, throwing off their rhythm. The wild rice was so thick we had to literally beat our way through it with the oars.

Finally, after days of misery, I saw the white walls of Fort Winnebago sitting on a high hill above the swamps.

The Native Americans have a legend that a massive serpent once lived in the Mississippi. He got bored, crawled across the prairies to visit the Great Lakes, and the heavy rains filled his massive trail to create the Fox River. The little lakes are where he tossed and turned in his sleep. He must have thrashed like a kitten near the Portage.

"Look!" I yelled. "We'll be there in thirty minutes!"

My husband just smiled. "Wait and see."

We rowed directly toward the fort. We could see the officers standing on the bank waiting for us. Then, the river turned violently, and we were suddenly rowing away from them, back out into the swamp. We approached a row of log cabins.

"That's the Agency," my husband said. "The interpreter lives there, and that little building is the government blacksmith shop where the Indians get their guns fixed for free."

"Are we stopping there?"

"No, look. The river is turning again."

We spent two full hours tacking left, right, backward, and forward through the snake-like river before we finally hit the landing where everyone was waiting to greet us.

CHAPTER VIII: Fort Winnebago

Major and Mrs. Twiggs, a few junior officers, and my brother-in-law Robert (known to the Native tribes simply as "Bob") gave us an incredibly warm welcome. You can

only understand that level of hospitality if you have traveled to a remote, isolated outpost in the wilderness.

The Major refused to let us stay at the Agency house and insisted we take the vacant quarters inside the fort. Mrs. Twiggs hadn't seen another white woman in over four months, and she wasn't about to let me out of her sight. Our heavy furniture was still slowly making its way up the river from Green Bay, so we were their guests in the meantime.

They had a massive dinner ready for us. One of the few benefits of the agonizing, zigzagging Fox River approach is that the fort can see you coming for two hours, so you never catch anyone by surprise.

After dinner, Mrs. Twiggs showed me the rooms assigned to us across the hall. The space was huge—two large rooms on each of the three floors. The back room on the ground floor was clearly the bedroom, mostly because it contained a massive, unwieldy wooden bedframe that looked big enough to sleep an absolute giant. We couldn't stop laughing at it, but it was nothing compared to the other piece of "furniture" in the room.

A young lieutenant had supervised the construction of what was supposed to be a closet. He and the soldiers had clearly lost their minds. They had carved and grooved the wood, swelled the pillars out in bizarre shapes, and cut the doors into radiating panels. He had built one of these monstrosities for every set of quarters because the original architects forgot to include closets. Mrs. Twiggs was using hers as a china cabinet, even though the shelves were built so close together you couldn't even fit a gravy boat between them. We immediately named the structure a "Davis," in honor of the lieutenant who built it.

The fort sat on a high cliff. On one side, it looked down over the vast prairie and the Fox River. On the other side, a thick forest stretched out toward Lake Puckaway. Right in front of the fort was the Portage road—a two-mile stretch of swampy mud connecting the Fox and Wisconsin Rivers. The government kept a team of oxen there just to drag Native canoes across the mud.

The autumn leaves were brilliant, and the area was packed with Native Americans who had set up their lodges near the Agency buildings. Traders had pitched white tents across the low ground, ready to sell winter supplies to the tribes the second my husband handed out the silver annuity payments.

Just before we arrived, the massive crowd of natives had held a massive funeral. Chief Four-Legs—the man whose village we had passed on Winnebago Lake—had decided to start celebrating the annuity payment early. The traders had brought in a

massive supply of illegal whiskey, and without my husband there to stop it, Four-Legs drank himself to death.

His funeral had been a massive spectacle, and I was genuinely disappointed I missed it. They wrapped his body in a blanket, placed it in a rough wooden coffin with his guns, tomahawk, pipes, and tobacco, and carried him to the highest hill across from the fort. The entire tribe followed, howling, beating drums, and screaming in a massive *pow-wow*.

They planted a wooden stake at the head of his grave, painted in bright red vermilion with hieroglyphics detailing all his great deeds in life. Then they built a fence of tamarack logs around it. His friends would come back to the grave for days to cry and throw tobacco over the fence as an offering to the Great Spirit.

My husband had to pay the sutler's bill for the funeral supplies and provide white cotton for a flag to fly over the grave. It was expected that the "Father" of the tribes would cover the costs of a chief's burial.

The mourning hadn't stopped. All day and all night, the air was filled with howling, drumming, and the terrifying screams of drunk, grieving warriors. Occasionally, you could hear the sad, haunting notes of a wooden flute—the instrument young men play when they are in love. Grief and whiskey had made them overly emotional, and the woods echoed with it.

Early the next morning, I was startled by the sound of sobbing coming from the room next door. I walked in and found several Native women sitting on the floor, looking incredibly sad. In the middle of them sat a tiny, ugly woman wearing shredded rags. Her face was completely blackened with soot, her hair was a tangled mess, and she was crying hysterically.

I didn't speak their language, but I assumed the poor woman was destitute and starving. "How is it possible she only has these rags to wear?" I thought.

I ran to my room, grabbed a nice calico dress, and handed it to the crying woman. She took it and just kept sobbing. I tried to use hand gestures to explain how to put it on and that it would make her feel better.

The other women immediately burst out laughing.

I thought they were being incredibly cruel until my husband walked in. He explained that the crying woman was Madame Four-Legs, the chief's widow. She had plenty of nice clothes at home, but Native tradition required a widow to wear rags and cover her face in soot while mourning. I had completely misread the situation.

My husband shook her hand and spoke to her in a rough, guttural language, eventually dismissing her with a promise of some presents to help dry her tears. Madame Four-Legs wasn't faking her grief; she genuinely loved her husband. She was a Fox woman who spoke Chippewa, the "court language" of the tribes, so she often acted as his interpreter and political advisor. She was incredibly sharp and fiercely loyal.

After breakfast, the major chiefs dressed up in their best clothes and war paint to meet their new "mother."

First was Naw-kaw (The Walking Turtle), the new principal chief of the Winnebagoes. He was a massive man with a broad face and a giant lower lip that hung down to his chin.

Then came old Day-kau-ray, the most noble and dignified chief of any tribe. He had a striking Roman nose, a bald head with one single tuft of silver hair tied back on his shoulders, and impeccable manners. He dressed simply but carried himself like royalty.

Next was Black-Wolf. He looked exactly like his name—angry, sullen, and dangerous. While most Winnebago warriors shaved part of their heads and tied the rest back in a club decorated with beads and eagle feathers, Black-Wolf wore his thick black hair hanging loose around his face, which made him look even more terrifying.

Then came Talk-English, an incredibly handsome, heavily muscled young warrior. The year before, he had gone to Washington with my husband to meet the President. On the trip, white people kept asking him, "Do you talk English?"

He eventually asked my husband what it meant. At the next stop, he jumped off the canal boat, ran up to the first white man he saw, shoved his face forward, and yelled, "Talk Eengeesh?"

"Yes," the man said. "Do you talk English?" "Ya-as," the warrior replied.

He was incredibly proud of his new name and insisted on being registered on the government payrolls as "Talk-English."

Then there was The Little Elk, the tribe's best orator. Henry Clay had once pointed him out as the smartest man in the Native delegation.

The White Crow was a Rock River chief who wore a black silk patch over his blind left eye, giving him a sinister, piratical look.

Then came "The Dandy," a young nephew of Chief Four-Legs. His outfit was absurd. He wore a bright shirt completely covered in rows of silver brooches, multiple silver arm-bands, and heavily embroidered leggings. He carried a feather fan in one hand and a small mirror in the other, stopping to stare at himself every five minutes. His face was painted in a dozen different colors.

He wasn't the only one obsessed with fashion. An older chief named Pawnee Blanc (The White Pawnee) showed up in full finery. He bowed to me with solemn dignity, then walked into my parlor and sat flat on the floor. I watched in absolute horror as he dumped the burning ashes from his pipe directly onto my beautiful new carpet.

Later that day, my piano was unpacked. It had survived the journey perfectly. The Native women crowded around it, screaming in shock and delight when I played it. One woman even peeked into the back of it, trying to figure out where the magic was coming from.

CHAPTER IX: Housekeeping

We needed to set up our house before our furniture arrived by boat. I spent days cutting and sewing my carpets with Mrs. Twiggs, and the wife of one of our French workers came over to help clean the rooms.

I had tried to hire a servant woman in Detroit and Green Bay, but everyone backed out when they realized how isolated the fort was and how dangerous the Natives could be. Major Twiggs solved the problem by offering me Louisa, a young Black girl he had brought from Buffalo. She claimed to be fifteen, but her absolute mastery of lying and manipulation proved she was much older. I naively thought I could train the bad habits out of her.

When the boats finally arrived with our furniture, the entire garrison ran down to the docks to help unload. It was a disaster. Water poured out of the wooden crates as they were hoisted onto the shore. The men grabbed hammers and smashed the boxes open. My expensive mahogany furniture was completely warped, the edges splitting and peeling. It looked like it had been sitting at the bottom of a waterfall for a week.

The boat captain swore it wasn't his fault, blaming the men, the weather, and the packing. There was nothing we could do but try to fix it. We scrubbed the wood, hung white curtains, unpacked the dishes, and arranged the parlor. The captain was mesmerized by the piano. He went back to Green Bay and told everyone, "It stood on four legs! And anyone could just walk up and touch it!"

My first attempt at cooking a dinner party happened by accident. I was in the kitchen trying to supervise Louisa when my husband walked in and announced he

had invited a massive French trader named M. Rolette and five other men over for dinner.

"I don't have anything ready!" I panicked.

"They've been living in tents for a week," he said. "They'll eat anything."

I had prepared a massive venison pie—the size of a small tire—and threw together a few side dishes. The dinner was a massive success.

CHAPTER X: Indian Payment

The government paid the Winnebago annuities in two places: the Portage and Prairie du Chien. Thousands of natives flooded into our area for the payout.

When it was time to distribute the money, the head of each family brought a bundle of sticks to the Agent to register the members of his household. It was a simple system, but the men constantly tried to cheat it.

"How many in your lodge?" the Agent would ask. "Fifteen," the Indian would say, dropping his sticks on the table. "How many men?" "Two." The Agent separated two sticks. "How many women?" "Three." Three more sticks moved. "How many children?" "Eight." Eight sticks moved. "What are these two extra sticks for?"

The warrior would grab his sticks and run away while his friends openly laughed at him for getting caught trying to scam the government.

The young military officers helped count out the silver coins. After the payout, the chiefs would often grab a handful of silver from the box and try to hand it to the officers as a tip. They were genuinely offended when the officers refused to take it.

The Native Americans were incredibly polite when it came to sharing food. If my husband gave a group of hungry warriors a basket of food, one man would divide it into exact, equal portions before anyone took a bite.

There was only one exception to this rule: Pawnee Blanc, the old dandy.

He brought a group of men to dance for us in the dusty yard. We sent out a pitcher of cold raspberry drink and a single glass. Pawnee filled the glass halfway, gave it to the first dancer, and passed it around the circle. Then he looked inside the pitcher, realized there wasn't much left, dropped the glass on the dirt, raised the pitcher to his mouth, and chugged the rest of it. Everyone laughed. It was the only time we ever saw an Indian panic about not getting his fair share.

When the annuity payments were finished, the massive influx of illegal whiskey usually led to chaos. Before the men started drinking, the Native women would quietly gather up all the guns, knives, and tomahawks and hide them in the woods to prevent murders.

Before we left the East, my husband had bought a trunk full of blue coats trimmed in gold lace and black top hats to give as presents to the chiefs. For a Native warrior, wearing a European hat covered in tinsel and feathers was the ultimate status symbol.

Pawnee Blanc got one of the gold-laced coats. He strutted around the fort all day, completely full of himself, a crowd of admiring women following him everywhere. But by late afternoon, the whiskey had won. We saw two young men dragging him out of a ditch. His beautiful gold coat was plastered in mud, his hat was crushed, and Pawnee was sobbing hysterically like a child.

I also became friends with the "Washington Woman," the shrewd wife of Chief Yellow Thunder. Because she had traveled to the East Coast, nothing at the fort impressed her. When the other women gasped at my household items, she just rolled her eyes as if to say, *I've seen it all before.*

The only thing that broke her apathy was a large, dark-veined tropical seashell. When she held it to her ear and heard the ocean, she smiled, completely fascinated by it.

When the tribes left after the payment, I realized my seashell was missing. Native women rarely stole, but the temptation was sometimes too much. I suspected the Washington Woman, even though she was supposedly "civilized."

A few weeks later, she walked into my parlor, unrolled a calico shawl, and placed the shell on my table. I didn't say a word. When my husband asked her why she took it without asking, she said, "Because I knew my mother liked the shell, and if I asked for it, she would say no."

Her blunt honesty wasn't surprising. During her trip to the East Coast, she realized that white people charged admission for everything—museums, theaters, shows. So, she locked the door to her hotel room and refused to let anyone in to see the Indian delegation unless they handed her a silver coin. She made a fortune before the Agent caught her. When a visitor tried to leave the room, she blocked the door and demanded *another* coin to let him out! The Agent had to explain that white people didn't charge their friends an exit fee.

During that same trip, the Native delegation was eating at a hotel in Ohio. They asked the Agent if he had to pay for all the food on the massive buffet table. When he

said yes, the men panicked. They grabbed everything—biscuits, whole chickens, sugar bowls—and dumped the food into their blankets so they wouldn't waste the money.

Later on the trip, the Agent tried to teach them table manners, telling them not to throw chicken bones on the tablecloth. At dinner, a massive roast turkey was brought out. A warrior realized he didn't know what to do with his bones, so he dumped them all on top of a nearby apple pie, grabbed the entire turkey, and walked off to share it with his friends. The white guests at the table couldn't stop laughing.

CHAPTER XI: Louisa – Day-kau-ray on Education

The annuity payment was over, and the Native Americans had dispersed to their winter hunting grounds. The traders packed up their silver and left. The Indians were smart negotiators—they knew exactly when a trader was trying to rip them off. M. Rolette was famously known among the tribes as "Five More," because no matter how many furs a native offered him in trade, his answer was always, "I need five more."

Once, a woman told Rolette that she could never be an Indian trader because she would feel guilty cheating the natives.

"Let me tell you something, madame," Rolette replied. "It is not easy to cheat an Indian. I've been trying to do it for twenty years, and I have never succeeded."

Life at the fort settled into a quiet routine dictated by the military bugle calls. It was peaceful, but on Sundays, I deeply missed my home in the East. I wanted to maintain the Sabbath, so I told my servant, Louisa, to clean up breakfast quickly so I could teach her some Bible lessons.

An hour passed. No Louisa.

I walked out to the main hall, which opened onto the parade ground, and found a crowd of people watching the soldiers run through their Sunday inspection. Right in the middle of the crowd was Louisa's head, bobbing up and down as she laughed.

"Louisa! What are you doing?" I asked. "I told you to clean the kitchen and come up for your lesson."

"I know, ma'am, but I had to watch the inspection! Everyone watches the inspection on Sunday."

I gave up on trying to teach her discipline.

I tried to organize a Sunday church service for the garrison, but when I asked if any of the officers were religious, I was told: "Well, Lieutenant S— is. When he gets

half-drunk, he takes his Bible to bed and cries over it. He thinks that makes him incredibly pious." I decided not to ask him to lead the service. We eventually petitioned the East Coast to send us a proper missionary.

Winter hit us hard. Our quarters were massive, but the soldiers had built them using green, unseasoned wood. As the wood dried, it shrank and warped, leaving massive gaps in the walls. We spent hours stuffing raw cotton into the cracks and gluing paper over them just to stop the freezing wind.

The chimneys smoked constantly. To fix it, the commanding officer had the blacksmith saw off two gun barrels and insert them into the brickwork to create a draft.

The next morning, Louisa was scrubbing the hearth and asked what the metal pipes were for. I explained they were gun barrels.

"Oh, thank God!" she gasped. "Uncle Ephraim told me they were packed with gunpowder and the major was going to blow up the house on Christmas Day!"

Uncle Ephraim, an older servant, loved terrifying the younger girls. He once convinced Louisa that all the Frenchmen at the fort were actually prairie-wolves who had learned to walk on two legs and talk, and that when they got old, they turned back into wolves.

The cold was unimaginable. Water froze in the parlor just a few feet from the roaring fire. The thermometer hit twenty-five degrees below zero—so cold that the brandy froze solid inside the dining room cabinet.

When Christmas and New Year's arrived, our Native friends returned. They had learned about the holidays from the French, which meant they expected presents. I had baked a massive pile of crullers and doughnuts to hand out.

To my horror, when I checked the kitchen, most of the cakes were gone. Louisa whined and blamed a soldier on the water-detail, but I knew she had handed them out to every soldier who walked past the door.

Early the next morning, the Native women sat in a circle on my parlor floor. I brought out a china dish full of brown crullers covered in white powdered sugar. I handed the dish to the first woman. She didn't take one. She dumped the entire bowl into the folds of her blanket and handed the empty dish back to me.

I was annoyed, but I went back to the kitchen, refilled the bowl, and held onto it tightly as I offered it to the next woman. She simply scooped out every single cake with both hands and dumped them into her blanket.

I sat down, trying to figure out how to feed everyone without running out of food in five minutes. While I was thinking, the women equitably divided the stolen cakes among themselves. But they didn't eat them. They stared at the white powder, muttering to each other. Finally, one woman wet her finger, touched the white sugar, and tasted it.

"Tah-nee-zhoo-rah! Sugar!" she screamed in delight. They all burst out laughing and devoured the cakes. They had never seen white sugar before; they thought it was salt.

Around this time, my husband received a letter from Colonel Richard M. Johnson of Kentucky, asking the Agent to convince the Winnebagoes to send their children to a white school in his state—and to use their treaty money to pay for it.

My husband called the chiefs together and read them the letter, explaining all the benefits of learning white civilization.

Old Chief Day-kau-ray stood up to answer.

"Father," he said, "the Great Spirit made the white man and the Indian, but he did not make them the same. He gave the white man a heart to love peace, build houses, make books, and farm. He gave the Indian a love of the woods, of hunting, and of making war. The white man cannot live like an Indian. And the Indian cannot live like a white man.

"Father, we do not want to anger the Great Spirit. If he wanted us to live like white men, he would have made us white. Because he did not, we believe he would be furious if we tried to change our nature. We will not send our children to your school."

It was a profound and unanswerable argument.

CHAPTER XII: Preparations for a Journey

In January, a massive blizzard buried the region in five feet of snow. We had planned to ride to Chicago for a visit, but the commanding officer threatened to have the guards shoot us if we tried to leave the fort in such brutal weather. We were forced to wait.

By early March, the snow began to melt, and we decided to attempt the trip on horseback. But I had a problem: I didn't own a riding habit.

The fort's tailor was summoned. He was actually a company cook who did tailoring on the side. To keep him out of the barracks, we let him work in our parlor.

He was a tiny, incredibly serious man who took off his shoes at the door and sat cross-legged on my floor. Neither of us had ever made a woman's riding habit before, so I had to cut the broadcloth myself while he stitched it together. He was absolutely thrilled with the result, constantly holding it up and declaring, "Upon my word, madam, this is a very respectable garment!"

While the tailor worked, our French servant, Mrs. Pillon, prepared our travel food: baked biscuits, boiled ham, tongue, and salt pork. We packed the food into cotton bags and leather sacks.

The route to Chicago was not direct. The ice was melting, meaning we couldn't cross the Rock River at Kosh-ko-nong. We had to ride south to Dixon's Ferry, a massive detour that would add days to our trip.

My husband selected two men for the journey: Pierre Roy and Plante, a French guide who swore he knew every inch of the trail. I picked a beautiful gray horse named "Le Gris," while Plante rode a massive, powerful horse named Jerry. My little pony, Brunet, was relegated to carrying the packs.

CHAPTER XIII: Departure from Fort Winnebago

On March 8th, we rode out of the fort. Major Twiggs tried one last time to talk us out of it, warning us the trail was dangerous, but I was determined. The junior officers rode with us for the first four miles to Duck Creek to see us off.

We brought an ox-cart carrying a canoe to cross the flooded marsh. Our French driver, Pillon, screamed and cursed at the oxen as they slammed into stumps. I was completely ignorant of the brutal reality of winter travel. I was wearing a straw hat and kid-leather gloves, treating the whole thing like a pleasant afternoon ride. I even refused my husband's advice to wear thick woolen socks.

When we reached the freezing, ice-choked creek, the men stripped the saddles off the horses and swam them across. My husband put me in the center of the canoe and told me to sit flat on the bottom.

"No," I said, "I'll just sit on this trunk. It's more comfortable."

He pushed the canoe off the bank. At that exact second, our two greyhounds leaped from the shore and landed squarely on top of me. The canoe flipped, and I was instantly plunged into the freezing water.

My husband grabbed me by the collar and dragged me back to the bank. I was laughing, but everything we owned was soaked. The situation got even funnier when Pillon tried to ride the massive horse, Jerry, across the marsh. Jerry bucked, launching the screaming Frenchman headfirst into the freezing water.

"Well," my husband said, "I am not trusting you in the canoe again."

He hoisted me onto his shoulders and waded across the freezing swamp himself, staggering under the weight. When we reached the other side, he begged me to stop and build a fire to dry my clothes. I refused, embarrassed that the officers watching from the other bank would laugh at us.

We rode twenty-three miles that day, finally camping in a grove near the Four Lakes. I realized the brutal reality of the weather when I took off my wet riding habit and draped it over a log near the fire—it froze absolutely solid in minutes, standing upright on its own like a ghost.

Dinner was a rough affair. We used the French method: hold a biscuit in your left hand as a plate, drop a piece of ham on it, and cut it with a hunting knife without slicing your hand open.

The next morning, we were woken by my husband screaming "How! how! how!" The men struck the tent, packed the horses, and we rode out.

The trail was a nightmare. The prairie was covered in half-thawed snow, and the horses floundered through the deep slush. Our guide, Plante, was nearly thrown from his horse multiple times.

By the time we reached the Blue Mound, a massive hill, I was completely exhausted. I literally fell out of the saddle into my husband's arms. He panicked, swearing we had to turn around and go back to the fort.

But the door of the nearby cabin opened, and we were welcomed by Mrs. Morrison and Elizabeth Dodge. They stripped off my frozen clothes, rubbed my hands, and gave me hot wine. The house was a rough log cabin, but the food was incredible. Mrs. Morrison told me that during her first eighteen months out there, she hadn't seen a single white woman.

While we were talking, a local Tennessee woman walked in with her son. Her face was sunburned brick-red, her hair was tied up in a tight, bizarre knot, and she looked absolutely terrified of us. Her son just walked up to Mrs. Morrison, pulled his hat over his eyes, and demanded a "whang"—a strip of smoked deer-skin. She cut him a piece, and they ran out of the cabin.

I went to sleep that night completely exhausted, but determined to press on.

CHAPTER XIV: William S. Hamilton – Kellogg's Grove

The next morning, after a massive breakfast, we packed up to leave. I had convinced my husband not to turn back, promising him I felt completely refreshed and ready for the trail.

Mr. Morrison gave us complicated directions to reach our next stop, Hamilton's "diggings." The prairie out here has zero landmarks. Every rolling hill looks exactly the same, and an Indian trail isn't a wide road—it's just a narrow, sunken rut in the grass worn down by single-file horses. If you lose the trail, you are just as lost as a ship in the middle of the ocean.

Our French guide, Plante, swore up and down that he knew the route. "I know every hill, stream, and piece of wood between here and Chicago," he bragged.

It didn't take long to realize Plante had absolutely no idea where he was going. He led us completely off the path, and my husband had to take the lead.

We rode all day across a dead, frozen, empty prairie. We didn't see a single tree or stream. The only break in the landscape were massive, grave-like holes dug by desperate men looking for lead veins. The wind was brutal, and we were so terrified of being lost that we didn't even stop when a gaunt prairie wolf stared us down from a ridge. We just pushed the horses harder.

Just before sunset, we crossed a muddy stream and found a pathetic patch of trees to camp in. We had ridden fifty miles. I was too stressed to feel tired; the terrifying reality of being completely lost in the freezing wilderness was keeping me awake.

The wind ripped through the camp that night. It started snowing heavily, and the weight of the snow snapped the tent poles, dropping the freezing canvas directly onto us. My husband and the men had to run into the woods in the pitch black to chop new poles while I lay under the collapsed tent, holding the heavy, freezing canvas off my face.

We woke up the next morning to a completely whiteout blizzard. We had no compass, and we couldn't even see the sun to figure out which direction was east. I tied a silk handkerchief over my face to stop the ice from slicing my skin, but I was freezing to death.

We rode blindly for miles, desperate to find an Indian wigwam or any sign of life. Suddenly, someone screamed, "A fence! A fence!"

It was the most beautiful thing I had ever seen. We rode down a hill and found a cluster of miserable, shabby log cabins. It didn't matter what they looked like; it was shelter from the blizzard.

"Whose cabins are these?" my husband yelled at a man chopping wood.

"Hamilton's," the man said.

We were dragged into the warmest cabin. A pale, exhausted woman was rocking a fat baby in a wooden bread-trough near a roaring fire. My husband peeled the frozen clothes off me and went to check on the horses.

He was gone for a long time. When he finally came back, he was laughing. He told me that William S. Hamilton—the son of Alexander Hamilton—was the owner of the camp. Hamilton had been hiding from me because he was deeply embarrassed that a woman from the East Coast was going to see him living like a savage in the dirt.

Hamilton eventually came in, and despite his rough clothes, he was just as polite and charming as you'd expect a Hamilton to be.

When the dinner horn blew, a dozen lead miners flooded into the room. They were the roughest, most terrifying men I had ever seen. They wore deer-skin hunting shirts, carried massive knives in their belts, and looked like straight-up bandits. They all called Hamilton "Uncle Billy," and I realized quickly that he had to act like their equal just to keep them from killing him.

One of the miners stayed behind after dinner and started interrogating us. It was immediately obvious he was an army deserter hiding out in the mines. His face twisted in rage as he talked about his old commanders at Fort Winnebago, bragging about how someone was going to shoot them the second they stepped off the fort. I was terrified until he finally walked out.

Hamilton spent the afternoon with us, telling incredible stories about his early life in New York and his wild adventures on the frontier. He even loaned us a copy of his father's biography to read. It was surreal sitting in a freezing, dirt-floor cabin reading about Alexander Hamilton while his son hid from the snowstorm outside.

That night, we slept in the same room as the miner, his wife, and their baby. The only "privacy" we had was a rope strung across the room with a few petticoats thrown over it. The miners weren't shy; they just tossed their dirty clothes over the rope and went to sleep.

The next morning, the sun was shining. Hamilton offered to guide us to the next settlement, twenty-five miles away. As we rode out, the miner told us, "I pity you. You made a terrible mistake coming out here. Comfort never touched this Western country."

Hamilton rode like a maniac, plunging down steep ravines at full speed. I was riding a massive, powerful horse named Jerry, and he refused to be left behind. My hat got caught in a tree branch, and I was nearly ripped out of the saddle before my husband saved me.

My biggest problem was my pack pony, Brunet. He hated being in the back of the line. Every time we crossed a freezing river, Brunet would wait until I was in the middle of the water, then charge past me, splashing me with ice water and nearly knocking Jerry over. It was infuriating.

We rode thirty miles without stopping until we reached Kellogg's Grove. Mrs. Kellogg, a very respectable woman from New York, fed us an incredible dinner of ham, fresh eggs, and johnny-cake.

Mr. Kellogg decided he wanted to ride with us to Chicago the next day. He packed exactly two days' worth of food, assuming it would be a fast trip. My husband begged Mrs. Kellogg to bake us extra biscuits, knowing how dangerous the trail was. Mr. Kellogg complained about the extra weight, but my husband's paranoia saved our lives.

That night, we slept in a room with six male strangers, but I was so exhausted I didn't care.

CHAPTER XV: Rock River – Hours of Trouble

We left Kellogg's the next day and rode to Dixon's Ferry on the Rock River. The ferry boat had been smashed by ice the week before, so we had to cross in a tiny rowboat while the men forced the horses to swim through the freezing water.

Mr. Dixon and his wife took us in. Sitting by their fire, I noticed a Native American boy staring blankly into the ashes. He was wearing a calico shirt and leggings.

"Who is that?" I asked.

"That's John Ogie," a little girl told me. "He's fretting for his mother. Some people say she's dead, but I think she's buried out there in the yard."

The boy's father was an abusive, alcoholic Canadian who had driven the mother away. She fled back to her tribe, leaving the boy behind. He eventually tracked her down years later when the government forcibly relocated the tribes to Missouri.

Mr. Dixon assured us the rest of the trip to Chicago would be easy. "Just follow the great Sauk trail," he said. "Two guys walked it in two days last fall. You'll be fine."

The next morning, we rode east. After six miles, we hit a faint trail heading northeast.

My husband stopped. "This isn't the Sauk trail. It's too faint, and it goes too far north."

Our guide, Plante, was absolutely furious. "I know this trail!" he bragged. "I shot ducks on that exact ridge right there last year! This is the way!"

Mr. Kellogg agreed with Plante. My husband yielded, and we followed the guide.

Hours later, the trail hit a massive, rocky bluff over the river. It was a dead end.

"Are you satisfied now, Plante?" my husband asked bitterly. "I am the pilot now."

The weather turned violently cold. We hadn't bought extra food at Dixon's because we needed the horses to carry grain. We camped in a freezing patch of woods, our water completely frozen solid by midnight.

The next morning, we woke up to a nightmare. We had to cross a massive, frozen swamp. The ice was too thin to hold the horses, so they broke through with every step, the jagged ice slicing their legs to ribbons. We had to backtrack for hours just to get around it.

Then a blinding snowstorm hit. We had no compass, no trail, and no sun to guide us. We rode blindly until we hit a deep trail running north to south.

"We need to go south," my husband said. "We are way too far north."

"No!" Plante and Mr. Kellogg argued. "We are too far south! We have to go north!"

Against his better judgment, my husband turned north. We rode for miles while Mr. Kellogg complained constantly. Finally, my husband snapped. "You can go north if you want. I am going south. Follow me or don't."

We turned around and rode south for hours. Just before dark, we found a cluster of Native wigwams. We screamed in joy and rode up to them—only to realize the camp

was completely abandoned. The tribe had taken everything and gone to their winter hunting grounds.

We camped in the snow. We were out of food. The dogs whined for scraps, but we had nothing but bare bones.

The next morning, we searched the food bags. We had exactly three crackers left. The men gave them to me and told me to put them in my pocket. Mr. Kellogg, who hadn't packed enough food, guiltily handed me a slice of fruitcake he had been saving. He had been eating our food for two days, and now we were all starving.

We rode until we hit a massive, fast-moving river. The banks were choked with jagged ice. There were wigwams on the other side, but no one answered when the men screamed across the water.

We rode down the bank, terrified and desperate. Suddenly, my horse started panicking. A small dog ran out of the bushes and barked at us. It was the most beautiful sound in the world.

We found two Native women hiding in the brush, digging for roots. My husband spoke to them in Potawatomi and asked them to take us across the river. They had a tiny canoe, barely big enough for one person.

"Will you go alone?" my husband asked me.

"Yes."

I lay flat on my back in the freezing water at the bottom of the canoe while the women paddled me across. When I hit the other side, I sat on a frozen log in the snow.

For the first time on the trip, I completely broke down. I wasn't crying because I was cold or hungry. I was crying because I was utterly, hopelessly broken. The sheer desolation of the wilderness crushed me. The Native women just stared at me in pity, wondering why a woman wearing expensive clothes on a massive horse was sobbing in the dirt.

I wiped my eyes, stood up, and promised myself I wouldn't cry again.

CHAPTER XVI: Relief

The women took us to their wigwam. It was beautifully woven and warm. A massive kettle was boiling over a fire in the center. I was starving, and when the woman handed me a bowl of boiled artichoke roots, it was the greatest thing I had ever eaten.

The Native children stared at me in shock when I pulled a book out of my pocket and started reading. They had never seen a book before.

Suddenly, a tall, handsome hunter bounded into the wigwam. He was the owner of the lodge, returning from a duck hunt. He was incredibly calm and polite, immediately offering to guide us to a white settlement called Piché's Grove. He told us a massive storm was coming and that we needed to camp immediately while he went out to shoot more ducks for us.

Before we left the wigwam, I pulled a roll of red silk ribbon from my pocket, cut it with my hunting knife, and tied it into the little girls' hair. They were thrilled.

The storm hit with terrifying violence. The wind screamed through the trees, snapping massive trunks around our camp. If we had been one hour later to the river, we never would have made it across.

The smoke from the fire was blinding, blowing directly into our faces no matter where we sat. We ate a rough soup of ducks and roots, and I crawled into the tent to escape the smoke. We didn't sleep. We lay awake listening to massive trees crashing to the ground all around us. By morning, fifty giant trees had fallen around our camp.

Our Native guide led us out of the woods to Piché's log cabin, but the owner wasn't home. The cabin was packed with random travelers, including a tall Quaker who offered to guide us to Chicago.

The wind across the open prairie was brutal. I beat my feet against the saddle to keep the blood flowing until they went completely numb. We reached the Du Page River, but the ice was too thin to hold the horses. Plante had to ride his pony into the freezing water and smash the ice with an axe to cut a path. My idiot pony, Brunet, immediately charged in behind him, shivering and shaking in the ice water just to spite me.

We finally reached a large house owned by a family named Hawley. We felt like we were back in civilization. The woman sliced a massive ham, fried a dozen eggs, and baked a giant johnny-cake. We ate like starving wolves.

We rode out immediately after dinner to cross the east fork of the Du Page. The river was flooded, and the ice was breaking apart into massive, floating chunks. My horse had to dive into the rushing water and fight his way across. I clung to the mane, terrified I was going to be swept away.

Our Quaker guide talked my ear off the entire ride, preaching about how he had reached religious perfection and no longer committed sins. I was too frozen to argue with him.

We reached Lawton's tavern on the Des Plaines River just after dark. The river was frozen, and we had to scream for someone to come out, smash the ice, and row us across in a canoe. Mrs. Lawton was miserable, complaining constantly about being tricked into moving to the wilderness.

The next morning, we rode the final twelve miles into Chicago. We saw two massive trees in the distance that my husband had planted when he was a boy. We finally reached the tavern at Wolf Point. The landlady stared at us in shock.

"You rode through that storm?" she gasped. "The river just froze solid two days ago!"

My husband refused to risk the horses on the ice, so we walked the last half-mile to his family's mansion. A half-breed servant saw us coming and ran inside screaming.

"Madame Kinzie! Monsieur John and his wife just walked here from Fort Winnebago!"

We fell into the arms of our family. For that one day, I was an absolute legend, the woman who survived the brutal winter trail.

CHAPTER XX: Captivity of J. Kinzie, Sen. – An Amusing Mistake

The day after the Chicago massacre, General Hull surrendered Detroit to the British. One of the conditions of the surrender was that the civilians wouldn't be harmed. The Kinzie family moved into an old mansion in Detroit and tried to survive the winter.

It was a horrific time. The British allowed their Native allies to torture and murder American prisoners right in the streets of Detroit. The locals were forced to watch captive soldiers dragged through the snow, bleeding and starving, and forced to dance for the amusement of the warriors.

The civilians did everything they could to buy the prisoners from the tribes. They traded their clothes, their furniture, and everything they owned to ransom the Americans. The Kinzie house was turned into a makeshift hospital. In one final, desperate bargain, a servant traded a broken-down white horse—the very last thing the family owned—to save a captured Black servant.

Mr. Kinzie joined his family in Detroit in January. Shortly after, the British commander, General Proctor, got paranoid that Kinzie was secretly communicating with the American army. Proctor ordered him arrested.

Mrs. Kinzie immediately told her Native friends. The chiefs marched directly to Proctor's headquarters and demanded he release "their friend." Proctor backed down. A few days later, Proctor tried again, sending dragoons to arrest Kinzie. The Native warriors found out, grabbed canoes, rowed across the river, and forced Proctor to back down a second time.

The third time, Proctor finally succeeded. He had Kinzie thrown in heavy iron chains and dragged to Fort Malden in Canada. While imprisoned, Kinzie was allowed a brief walk along the river. One day, he heard massive cannons firing on Lake Erie. He begged his guards to let him stay outside until the firing stopped. When he saw a British ship strike its colors and surrender, he smiled. "I will go back to prison contented," he told the guards. "I know how the battle went." It was Commodore Perry's legendary victory on Lake Erie.

Proctor eventually tried to ship Kinzie to England as a prisoner of war. They tied him to a horse and forced him to ride to Quebec. The saddle slipped, and Kinzie was left hanging upside down, his legs tied to the horse, screaming in agony while the guards laughed. They finally put him on a ship, but it was chased back to port by an American frigate. The British finally gave up and released him.

In 1816, the Kinzie family returned to Chicago. Fort Dearborn was rebuilt. The bones of the soldiers massacred four years earlier were finally gathered from the sand dunes and buried.

Life in Chicago went back to being quiet and isolated. Food was so abundant that when a rare ship arrived, the settlers had to beg the captain to take their extra corn and butter just to get rid of it. Mail arrived maybe twice a year, carried by a runner who had to sleep in trees to avoid being murdered by hostile tribes.

Strangers rarely visited. Once, a traveler from the south rode up to a trading post at Wolf Point and asked for a room. The traders told him they didn't have space, but directed him to the "comfortable house" down the river—the Kinzie mansion.

The traveler rode up, knocked on the door, and told the women inside that he needed a room and boarding for his horse.

Because people in the wilderness were so hospitable, the family didn't correct him. They cooked him a massive dinner. He kicked off his boots, demanded a boot-jack, and

ordered his breakfast for the next morning. The family played along, laughing behind his back.

When he finally tried to leave, he asked for his bill.

"My house is not a tavern, sir," Mrs. Kinzie replied.

The man was absolutely mortified. He apologized profusely, but the family thought the whole thing was hilarious.

John Kinzie, the man who built Chicago and survived the massacre, died in 1828. He always knew Chicago was going to be a massive, prosperous city, but he never lived to see it happen.

CHAPTER XXI: A Sermon

Chicago in 1831 wasn't the happy place it used to be. Several prominent people had recently died, and the weather was violently stormy. My husband, who had tried to ride back to Fort Winnebago, got pinned down in a blizzard and had to hide in an Indian lodge for days.

Our only entertainment was riding horses along the lake. We used to stop and talk to Dr. Harmon, who was building a sod fence and planting fruit trees. He was absolutely convinced that Chicago was destined to become a great city. Looking around at the empty swamps and sand dunes, we almost believed him.

The women spent their afternoons shooting pistols at targets on the fort's walls. Some of the women became incredibly good shots.

The only drama inside the fort happened when a local settler was caught selling milk-punch (heavily spiked milk) to the soldiers. The military drummed the guy out of the fort and threw the drunk soldiers into the guardhouse. The commander's wife felt bad for the prisoners and brought them hot coffee and pancakes, which made the other soldiers actively try to get thrown into the guardhouse.

One Sunday, we went to a church service led by Father See. He was a tall, messy man in a green coat who absolutely butchered his sermons. He got so tangled up in his own metaphors about the "fear of God" that he finally stopped, wiped his sweating forehead with a filthy handkerchief, and said, "Come, let's stop a little while, and clear away the brush." He tried to start over, got confused again, and finally just yelled that he hoped we all soared away on the rolling clouds of aether. We decided to just pray at home after that.

Around this time, my brother-in-law Robert secured the title to "Kinzie's Addition"—a 102-acre chunk of Chicago. His mother told him he should claim another 58 acres at Wolf Point, just to be safe.

Robert laughed at her. "We have 102 acres! That is more land than we will ever need or know what to do with! Why would I claim more?"

No one claimed the extra land because they didn't want to look greedy. In hindsight, fifty years later, that was a spectacularly bad decision.

CHAPTER XXII: The Captives

During my stay in Chicago, my mother-in-law, Eleanor Lytle, told me the story of her childhood.

In 1779, her family lived on the frontier in Pennsylvania. One afternoon, nine-year-old Eleanor and her seven-year-old brother were playing in the woods behind their house. A group of Seneca warriors silently stepped out of the trees, grabbed the children, and dragged them into the forest.

The warriors also captured their mother and her three-month-old baby. The father was away working. As the warriors force-marched the captives through the woods, the baby started crying. One of the warriors grabbed the infant by the feet and smashed its brains out against a tree. The mother, knowing she would be killed if she screamed, stayed completely silent and kept walking.

After days of marching, they reached the Seneca village in New York. The leader of the war party, a chief known as the Big White Man, took little Eleanor to his mother.

"I bring you a child to replace my brother who was killed," he said. "She will be my sister."

The father of the family eventually tracked them down with the help of soldiers from Fort Pitt. He managed to ransom his wife and the other children, but the Big White Man absolutely refused to give up Eleanor. "She is my sister," he said. "I will not part with her."

The father was forced to leave his nine-year-old daughter behind.

Eleanor lived with the tribe for four years. The chief and his mother treated her like absolute royalty. They covered her in silver brooches and wampum and gave her the best food. She eventually learned the language, forgot her old life, and became completely happy.

The only problem was the chief's wife. She hated Eleanor with a burning, violent jealousy. While the chief was away on a hunting trip, Eleanor got sick with a fever. The chief's wife brought her a bowl of medicine.

Eleanor saw the woman glaring at her through a crack in the wall. A young Native friend whispered to Eleanor, "Do not drink that. She is trying to kill you. It is poison."

The bowl was full of crushed May-apple root, a deadly poison. When the chief returned and found out his wife had tried to murder his adopted sister, he banished the woman to the fields to hoe corn like a slave.

Finally, after the Revolutionary War ended in 1783, a British Agent named Colonel Johnson convinced the Big White Man to bring Eleanor to a treaty council at Fort Niagara. When the chief saw Eleanor's mother waiting on the riverbank, weeping for her child, his heart finally broke.

"She shall go," the chief said. "The mother must have her child again. I will go back alone."

He handed Eleanor over, turned his horse around, and disappeared into the forest. She never saw him again, but she loved him for the rest of her life.

CHAPTER XXIII: Second-Sight – Hickory Creek

At fourteen, Eleanor married a British officer, Colonel McKillip. He was killed in 1794 when his own sentinel accidentally shot him in the dark.

During her widowhood, Eleanor lived with her parents near Detroit. Her younger brother, Thomas, was her favorite sibling. One spring afternoon, Thomas rode off to visit his fiancée.

Later that day, Eleanor was sitting by a window when she saw Thomas walking up the path. He was soaking wet, carrying his heavy horse saddle on his own shoulders. He stopped, stared directly into her eyes with a terrifying, blank expression, and didn't say a word. Then he walked toward the stables.

Eleanor ran outside to find him, but he was gone. She asked her mother where he went.

"You were dreaming," her mother said. "Thomas went to the river."

The next morning, a messenger arrived. Thomas and his horse had drowned while trying to cross the flooded river. Based on the timeline, Thomas had drowned at the

exact second Eleanor saw him standing outside her window. She believed it was a warning from God.

Meanwhile, back in 1831 Chicago, the young bachelors of the town were invited to a massive dance at the Hickory Creek settlement. Robert Kinzie, Gholson Kercheval, and Medard Beaubien dressed in their absolute best clothes, mounted their finest horses, and rode out to steal all the local country girls.

The party was a massive success. The Chicago boys danced all night, completely humiliating the local farm boys and monopolizing the girls' attention.

At dawn, the arrogant Chicago boys walked out to the stables to get their horses. The local farm boys had exacted their revenge. They had completely shaved the manes and tails off the Chicago boys' beautiful horses. The majestic animals looked like giant, mutated rats.

The Chicago boys were absolutely humiliated. They had to ride their bald, ridiculous-looking horses all the way back across the open prairie in broad daylight, while everyone in the settlement laughed at them. They never went back to Hickory Creek.

Finally, the schooner Napoleon arrived to take the rest of the garrison to Green Bay. After days of chaotic loading, we waved goodbye to our family and prepared for our own journey back to Fort Winnebago.

CHAPTER XXIV: Return to Fort Winnebago

We packed light for the return trip. I rode a pacer, my mother-in-law rode another, and we took a light wagon driven by my husband. We brought along Harry, the Black boy, and Josette, the little half-breed girl. We all wore bizarre linen masks with painted-on faces to protect our skin from the brutal prairie wind. We looked completely terrifying.

When we stopped at a trading post on the Des Plaines River, two Native men took one look at our masked faces and screamed, "Spirits!" before running out the door in absolute terror.

The trip was beautiful until we reached the Fox River. The river looked shallow, but the bottom was pure, treacherous yellow clay. The wagon horses stepped in and immediately sank to their chests.

The horses panicked, thrashing and screaming in the mud, tangling themselves in the heavy harnesses. They were drowning. My husband jumped onto the wagon pole,

grabbed my hunting knife, and started slicing the leather straps to free them. Harry sprinted into the freezing water and cut the final straps.

The horses scrambled up the bank, dragging the shattered, splintered wagon pole with them. We were stranded on the wrong side of the river with a broken wagon and destroyed harnesses.

My sister-in-law Margaret had been trapped in the wagon during the chaos. We dragged her out, but the shock sent her into a violent fit of malarial ague. She lay in the tall grass, blue and shivering uncontrollably.

I grabbed an awl and some waxed thread and sat in the dirt, trying to stitch the shredded leather harnesses back together by hand, blistering my fingers in the process. The men chopped down a tree and started carving a new wagon pole.

Suddenly, we heard a violent hissing sound. "Rattlesnake!" someone screamed.

A massive rattlesnake slithered through the grass, passing three inches from my mother-in-law's feet. The men grabbed whips and rocks and beat it to death.

The sheer terror of the snake attack acted as an adrenaline shot for Margaret. It completely shocked the ague right out of her system. By the time I finished sewing the harnesses, she was perfectly fine and ready to ride.

We pressed on, reaching Crystal Lake just as the sun set.

CHAPTER XXV: Return Trip, Continued

The next day, we rode north toward Big-Foot Lake. The Native tribes out here have a legend for every animal. They say the little rail bird has a hunched, concave back because of the trickster spirit, Nan-nee-bo-zho.

The spirit told a flock of ducks he would teach them to dance. He made them close their eyes and started playing a flute. As they danced, he secretly grabbed them one by one, broke their necks, and shoved them into his bag. One little rail bird opened its eyes, saw the slaughter, and screamed, "Run! He is killing us!"

The bird tried to fly away, but the spirit grabbed it by the back. The bird violently wrenched itself free and escaped, but the spirit's grip permanently crushed its spine, leaving it hunched over forever.